

# Lesson 6: Networking and Professional Communication

Course 18: Professional Presence & Opportunity Building — Digital Independence Path

## What Is Networking, Really?

Forget the awkward image of "networking" you might have in your head — messaging strangers, forcing small talk, asking people you don't know for favors. That's not what this lesson is about, and it's not good networking anyway.

**Real networking, at your age, means staying in touch with people who already know you** — in a way that's clear, respectful, and genuine. It's your former teacher, a coach, a family friend who works in a field you're curious about, or an instructor from a program you took. You already have a network. This lesson is about using it well.

## Why It Matters

People are far more likely to help, advise, or remember someone they already have a real connection to than a stranger who messaged them out of nowhere. A short, thoughtful message to someone who knows you will almost always get a warmer response than a generic message blasted to fifty strangers. **Quality beats quantity, every time.**

## Networking Is NOT

- Messaging strangers you found online because they have a job you want.
- Copy-pasting the same message to dozens of people.
- Asking someone you just met for a big favor right away.
- Something you do without a trusted adult knowing.

## Safety Norms (Know These Before You Send Anything)

1. **A trusted adult (parent, guardian, or your instructor) should know about any outreach message before or as you send it.** This isn't about "asking permission" like you're a little kid — it's a normal professional practice: even adults loop in a mentor before an important email.
2. **You never meet someone from an online or written introduction in person alone.** If a conversation ever leads toward meeting up, that only happens with a trusted adult involved in the plan.
3. **LinkedIn requires you to be 16 or older.** If you're under 16, or you or your family prefer not to use it, you'll build the exact same skills using a personal portfolio page or a one-page PDF resume plus email — that path is just as

legitimate.

4. **Never share your address, school schedule, passwords, or financial information** in an outreach message, no matter who it's to.
5. **If a reply ever feels strange, pushy, or makes you uncomfortable — stop responding and tell a trusted adult right away.** That is always the right move, never something to feel embarrassed about.

## The Introduction Message Formula

A good outreach message is short — usually 80-150 words — and follows this shape:

1. **Greeting + who you are + shared context** (how do they know you?)
2. **Genuine reason for reaching out** (why them, why now?)
3. **A small, specific, low-pressure ask** (or no ask at all — just reconnecting counts)
4. **Gracious close + your full name**

That's it. No hard sell, no long life story, no big ask on the first message.

## Worked Example

**Scenario:** Jordan R., 17, wants to reconnect with Ms. Alvarez, who taught Jordan's sophomore-year Intro to Coding elective, to ask a quick question about a summer program.

**Jordan's message:**

Subject: Question from a former student — Jordan R.

Hi Ms. Alvarez,

I hope your school year is off to a good start! This is Jordan Reyes — I was in your Intro to Coding elective sophomore year (I sat near the front, and did the maze-solving robot project).

I'm applying to a summer coding program this year and remembered how much I enjoyed your class. Would you be open to answering one or two quick questions about how you got started in tech, whenever you have a few minutes? No pressure at all if you're busy — I completely understand.

Thank you for considering it, and I hope you're doing well!

Best, Jordan Reyes

**Ms. Alvarez's reply (a few days later):**

Hi Jordan,

So good to hear from you — I remember that robot project well! Happy to help. Feel free to send your questions over whenever, or we could do a quick 15-minute call if that's easier. Good luck with the application!

Ms. Alvarez

### Jordan's follow-up (same day):

Hi Ms. Alvarez,

Thank you so much for getting back to me! A quick call would be great if you have time — I'll let my mom know so she can help me find a time that works, and I'll send a couple options over email.

Thanks again, Jordan

Notice: Jordan mentions a trusted adult naturally as part of arranging a call — not as an afterthought. That's normal, professional, and safe, all at once.

### Activity: Draft Your Own Introduction Message

1. **List 3-5 real people already in your network** — a teacher, coach, family friend, relative, or past instructor. (Use the Worksheet to help brainstorm.)
2. **Pick one person** you'd genuinely like to reconnect with or ask a small question.
3. **Draft one real message to them** using the formula above, in a Google Doc.
4. **Decide how you'll loop in a trusted adult** — before you send it, share the draft with a parent/guardian or your instructor for a quick look.
5. Do **not** send the message during class. Take it home, get it reviewed, and send it with a trusted adult's awareness.

### Key Terms

| Term                          | Definition                                                                                                                                   |
|-------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Networking</b>             | Building and maintaining genuine professional relationships with people you know or are warmly introduced to — not mass-messaging strangers. |
| <b>Warm introduction</b>      | Being connected to a new person through someone you already know and trust, rather than reaching out cold.                                   |
| <b>Professional etiquette</b> | The expected norms of polite, clear, respectful communication in a professional context — tone, timing, gratitude, and follow-up.            |

### Knowledge Check

1. What is the main difference between networking and mass cold-messaging?
2. List the four parts of the introduction message formula in order.

3. True or False: You should ask for a big favor (like a job or internship) in your very first message to someone.  
Explain your answer.
4. Why should a trusted adult know about your outreach messages before you send them?
5. If you don't hear back from someone after a message, what should you do?

### Reflection Prompts

1. Who are 1-2 people already in your life who could be part of your professional network, and why did you pick them?
2. Think about a message you've received (from a friend, a group chat, an ad) that felt too pushy or impersonal. What made it feel that way, and how will you avoid that in your own outreach?
3. Why do you think "quality over quantity" is true for networking, even though it might feel slower or less impressive than reaching out to lots of people?

### Submission Instructions

Share your Google Doc containing: - Your list of 3-5 real network contacts (from the Worksheet) - Your one drafted introduction message - A one-sentence note on who your trusted adult is and how/when you'll share the draft with them

Submit the shared Google Doc link through your Lumexa dashboard for this lesson. Remember: **do not send your message before a trusted adult has seen it.**